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The persistence of gendered dating

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Abstract

The research on gendered dating demonstrates the remarkable staying power of the conventional norms that shape the practice. Heterosexual women and men rely on a proactive/reactive framework in which men take the lead and women respond. This is in spite of broad changes in patterns of relationship formation as well as increased commitment to egalitarian relationships which should conceivably shift how women and men date. Yet, as this review of the literature demonstrates, multiple challenges to these gendered expectations around dating, including a self-development imperative and extended period of independence before marriage, hookup culture on college campuses, and online dating, have failed to sufficiently challenge these gendered scripts. Heterosexual men and women locked out of these normative practices by economic constraints and social inequalities continue to desire them and struggle to enact rather than transform them. Moving forward, research should focus on the conditions under which sustained change does occur given the implications for research on gender inequality more broadly.

KEYWORDS

courtship, dating, gender, heterosexuality, hooking up, intimate relationships, online dating

1 | INTRODUCTION

Heterosexual dating presents us with a puzzle. Why, given the increased desire for gender equality in romantic relationships, do we still see traditional gender scripts guide dating behaviors? Most dates are initiated by men (England et al., 2008; Laner & Ventrone, 2000; Paytner & Leaper, 2016). Men are expected to plan and pay for the date, follow

up after a date, and move the relationship forward (Eaton & Rose, 2011; Lamont, 2020; Sassler and Miller, 2017). This extends to the point of the marriage proposal, which men are expected to initiate (Lamont, 2020; Sassler & Miller, 2011). This norm of men's initiation and women's reaction places men in the driver's seat of the relationship, reifying the agentic/communal binary ascribed to men and women (Ridgeway, 2011). This belief, in turn, justifies other forms of gender inequality, including the wage gap, occupational segregation, the household division of labor, the exclusion of women from leadership positions, and violence against women (Manne, 2020; Ridgeway and Correll, 2004).

But the persistence of these dating scripts is especially curious given that we have seen a number of changes in patterns of relationship formation that could plausibly challenge conventional gendered dating practices. Women's desire to secure educational credentials and careers prior to partnering has led to delays in marriage, especially among the highly educated (Hamilton & Armstrong, 2009; Sassler & Miller, 2017). When women marry men with similar credentials, the consolidation of their class privilege can allow for more egalitarian relationships, given that both partners bring similar resources to the partnership (Cherlin, 2009; Wong, 2017). Hookup culture on college campuses creates space for women to be sexually active outside of a committed relationship (Allison, 2019; Hamilton & Armstrong, 2009; Wade, 2017). The rise of dating apps and online dating mean that women now have a forum to explicitly express their interest in dating (Lundquist & Curington, 2019; McWilliams & Barrett, 2014). These shifts are supported by an increasing ideological commitment to egalitarian relationships (Gerson, 2010; Scarborough et al., 2019) and a greater mainstream visibility and embrace of queer identities and relationships that challenge the taken for granted ways of doing gender and building relationships (Lamont, 2017).

Yet although certain aspects of gendered relationship practices have changed, heterosexual dating remains surprisingly resistant to major transformation (Eaton & Rose, 2011; England, 2010). Research has shown that traditional norms of gendered dating persist, even in places and spaces we would expect to see shifts (Lamont, 2020). Women's increased professional opportunities and desire for egalitarian relationships have led to a transformation in expectations in the public sphere (England, 2010), but gendered dating is still viewed as a personal preference and not incompatible with these other desires and accomplishments (Lamont, 2014). Hookup culture on college campuses has shifted the pathways into committed relationships, but they are still shaped by a sexual double standard and relational imperative that ultimately constrain women (Allison, 2019; Bogle, 2008; Hamilton & Armstrong, 2009). And while online dating allows for new opportunities for people to meet prospective partners, men still send the vast majority of the messages (Rudder, 2014), conventional appearance norms shape who gets the most attention (Rudder, 2014), and women report high levels of sexual and gender harassment (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020a). In this overview of the literature on gendered dating, I show that these shifts have not radically remade dating practices, but rather have led heterosexual men and women to translate old inequalities into new dating spaces as they draw on preexisting beliefs about gender to guide social interaction. The questions left unanswered are: When and how do transformations in dating practices create openings for people to challenge traditional gender beliefs in the domain of heterosexual dating? Under what conditions do heterosexual men and women contest traditional gender beliefs that guide dating practices? These questions not only open up avenues for future research on dating practices; they reveal heterosexual dating as a strategic site for understanding when and why people uphold and contest gender norms that subordinate women in a wide range of social domains.

2 | THE RESILIENCE OF GENDERED CULTURAL SCRIPTS

In the 1920s, a shift from a calling to a dating system ushered in many of the current norms of men's initiation and the general guidelines for how a relationship should proceed (Bailey, 1988). Under the dating system, a man would ask a woman out on a date. He would then arrange to pick her up and spend a period of time with her in a public location, with him incurring any of the financial costs of the outing given the assumption of men's greater earning power (Bogle, 2008). After a series of dates, a couple could decide to commit to an exclusive relationship. While sexual activity

could occur during these dates, by no means was this a given (Bailey, 1988), although the working-class showed greater tolerance than the middle-class for premarital sex as part of a couple's pathway to marriage (Clements, 2006). These norms shifted the power to men to dictate the terms of dating and relationship progression (Bogle, 2008) and reified beliefs about the appropriate roles for men and women in heterosexual relationships (Bailey, 1988), with men associated with agency and the public sphere and women with nurturance and the private sphere (Ridgeway, 2011).

Since the 1960s, however, major changes in the gender system, often referred to as the "gender revolution" (England, 2010; Gerson, 2010), have challenged the gender inequality on which these dating conventions are premised. Women are now expected to be achievers in their own right, pursuing educational and professional opportunities once restricted to men, and supporting themselves financially (Cotter et al., 2004; England, 2010). These opportunities have led to delays in the average age at first marriage as both men and women put off long-term commitment in favor of investment in individual-level achievement (Arnett, 2004; Rosenfeld, 2007). The twenties are now a decade for self-investment as privileged young adults in particular follow a pathway from higher education to professional development before deciding to marry. This extended period between childhood and marriage means that young adults now have many potential years for dating and, especially, for dating as equals. This potential is compounded by the expressed desire on the part of both men and women for egalitarian relationships (Gerson, 2010; Lamont, 2020). And while the sexual double standard persists, it is less stringent than in the past (Bogle, 2008). As a result, dating scripts that require submission from women contradict expectations for behavior in other areas of their lives (Bell, 2013). In addition, new behavioral expectations call on so-called good and progressive men to balance their masculine performances with feminine traits and engage in more egalitarian behaviors (Bridges & Pascoe, 2014; Lamont, 2015). Yet research has shown that many of these transformations have left the conventions of the dating system intact.

While the desire for gender egalitarian relationships has gained traction then, there is still significant support for gender complementarity in romantic relationships, with gender-traditional femininity matched with gender-traditional masculinity (Hamilton, 2014; Schippers, 2007). This may be paired with the expectation that couples will settle into a gendered division of labor in which the woman takes care of the household and the man provides for the family economically (Hamilton, 2014). But often young adults actually articulate a mix of egalitarian and traditional beliefs about gender, more supportive of gender equality in the public sphere than in the home (Pepin & Cotter, 2018; Scarborough et al., 2019). This variation in beliefs reflects differences across social class, region, and religion, which shape the expectations for appropriate performances of gender (Gallagher & Smith, 1999; Hamilton, 2014; Scarborough & Sin, 2020; Scarborough et al., 2019).

The concept of egalitarian essentialism is useful for understanding how young adults' support for men's and women's equality of opportunity in the public sphere coexists with continued belief in essential gender differences and gender-differentiated behaviors in the private sphere (Charles & Grusky, 2004; Pepin & Cotter, 2018). From this ideological perspective then, men and women should have equality of opportunity and not face discrimination, but are still best suited for particular roles (Pepin & Cotter, 2018). This is compounded by a liberal individualism that encourages people to express their "true self" through their life choices, with that "true self" shaped by gender (Cech, 2013; England, 2010). People build gendered identities, and many take deep pleasure in gender normative performances (Risman, 2018). They rarely contest gender differentiation on principle alone. While there are material and status gains for women if they challenge gender inequality in the public sphere, the incentives to do so in intimate relationships are less tangible and the costs potentially higher, especially if they have internalized gendered interpersonal norms (England, 2010). Indeed, in some instances, women's gains in the workplace may lead to a greater desire for gender differentiation in intimate relationships (Gallagher & Smith, 1999; Pepin & Cotter, 2018).

As Ridgeway (2011) argues, we use gender as a primary frame, or as a way to make sense of ourselves and others, as well as to coordinate action based on our understandings about gender. To do so, we draw on "shared" or "common" knowledge about how to behave in certain social situations. Stereotypes about men and women are embedded in this knowledge, including both what they are like, and how they should behave as a result. These stereotypes are not only descriptive, but also prescriptive, in that they carry a value judgment toward behavior (Ridgeway, 2011, p. 58). These cultural scripts thus provide people with a blueprint for how to act in a particular situation (Gagnon, 1990).

People follow these scripts because they give people a sense of certainty about socially acceptable ways to proceed (Goffman, 1959). They may stray from these expectations, but they also understand that they may be held accountable (West & Zimmerman, 1989). Gender non-conforming behavior then, carries the risks of social sanctions (Ridgeway & Correll, 2004; Rudman & Fairchild, 2004).

Particularly resilient are people's beliefs about men's agency and women's communalism (Ridgeway, 2011). Men are believed to be more agentic, but also expected to be so. The same applies to women's support role. They are assumed and expected to be more nurturing and other oriented. These beliefs then shape how individuals approach their romantic relationships and are particularly compelling during moments of uncertainty, such as dating. People are getting to know each other and feel that it is a safer bet to simply conform rather than contest gender norms. Thus, we see the expectation for men to play the role of the initiator and for women to react and respond to them (Paytner & Leaper, 2016). Challenging these expectations potentially leads to anything ranging from an awkward encounter, to an unreturned phone call and no second date, to a hostile backlash (Lamont, 2020; Manne, 2018).

Thus, although we have seen major social changes in society, the gender system has proved remarkably resistant to them, as people embed these preexisting beliefs about gender and the gender hierarchy into new spaces and processes (Ridgeway & Correll, 2004). New activities simply lead to new forms of gender inequality that fail to disrupt the underlying beliefs on which they are premised. In this review of the research, I will show how this process plays out in four contexts in which we might otherwise expect to see challenges to the norms of gendered dating: hookup culture on college campuses; women's increased focus on independence and self-development; online dating; and among class-disadvantaged populations who lack the economic resources to follow normative practices. These examples demonstrate the staying power of gendered dating and the implications of these practices for gender inequality more broadly.

3 | THE IMPACT OF HOOKUP CULTURE ON DATING AND RELATIONSHIP FORMATION

The shift from dating to hookup culture in the 1970s dramatically changed heterosexual pathways into romantic relationships (Bogle, 2008), ostensibly opening up possibilities for young adults to approach them with fewer normative constraints. Most hookups, or non-relational sexual encounters, do not lead to committed relationships (England & Thomas, 2006; Wade, 2017). Instead, the expectation is for a no-strings-attached sexual encounter, which could mean anything from kissing to penetrative sex (Bogle, 2008; Wade, 2017). Contrary to popular belief, though, exclusive dating is not dead on college campuses (Allison, 2019; Kuperberg & Padgett, 2016). Thus, while most college hookups do not lead to a committed relationship, they are now the dominant means by which college students form relationships (England & Thomas, 2006). Although common, this is still a fraught prospect for the students involved. Because the encounter is premised on a lack of commitment, participants have to engage in delicate negotiations to transition to a committed relationship (Allison, 2019; Wade, 2017). Much of the hookup is built around an implicit lack of communication. Things are supposed to "just happen" and then the students go their separate ways (Lovejoy, 2015). As a result, it can be difficult for one of the partners to initiate a conversation about their motivations for a hookup (Glenn & Marquardt, 2001; Konstam et al., 2019). Even those who are hooking up in order to find a relationship know better than to say that upfront (Bogle, 2008; Wade, 2017).

But rather than alter gender dynamics, the ambiguity of the hookup still shapes the progression into relationships in gendered ways. Allison (2019) demonstrates that when college students use the formal date as a mechanism into committed relationships, they rely on gendered dating practices and norms. When they use hookups, however, they trade normative expectations for ambiguity. This ambiguity then simply trades on gendered understandings of who is more interested in commitment, disadvantaging women who have a harder time negotiating their own needs in these encounters as a result (Armstrong et al., 2010; Bogle, 2008; Fahs & Munger, 2015; Wade, 2017). Whereas women are expected to have a "relational" orientation to sex, men are expected to have a "recreational" one (Bernston

et al., 2014). But while women face a relational imperative, they are also consistently constrained in their ability to negotiate a committed relationship due to worries about charges of women's desperation and neediness (Bogle, 2008; Wade, 2017). In other instances, given the sense that men are especially reluctant to commit, women may also commit more quickly than they might otherwise prefer under the assumption that they have been presented with a rare opportunity (Hamilton & Armstrong, 2009). This narrative persists even though men are more likely than women to state they desire a long-term relationship (Kuperberg & Padgett, 2016). Thus, men have an easier time both keeping a hookup casual or transitioning to commitment.

The distinction between hooking up and dating also brings into sharp relief the sexism embedded in both. Women exchange the benevolent sexism they encounter in dating (Lever et al., 2015) for a careless approach to both their feelings and pleasure in hookups (Armstrong et al., 2012; Wade, 2017). Women who choose to avoid commitment in favor of casual hookups frequently report poor treatment at the hands of their partners. Men confirm this, stating that, without commitment, they feel no obligation to attend to their partners as people with needs and desires as well. The goal then is simply their own sexual pleasure and the use of women as tools for men's status building (Kimmel, 2008). This is more so true among white than Black men, who are more likely to express a romantic orientation to women in college partially due to concerns about heightened visibility and racial stereotyping on majority-white campuses (Ray & Rosow, 2010), although narratives about Black men as "players" who view women as sexual objects still circulate and shape college women's perceptions of Black men (Wilkins, 2012).

The hookup culture on college campuses also disadvantages less privileged groups and those who wish to opt out of the dominant social scene, reinforcing gendered social inequalities in the process (Armstrong & Hamilton, 2013; Wade, 2017). It is shaped by a hierarchy of desirability in which certain people are viewed as less attractive than others (Wade, 2017). While this reflects dominant, and racialized, beauty norms, it is also premised on beliefs about appropriate performances of femininity and masculinity. Wilkins (2012) found that Black men discussed passing over Black women as partners, claiming they were too demanding and not submissive enough when compared to white women. Wade (2017) too shows how race and gender intersect to limit hookup opportunities for particular groups. Women of color do not find hookups as sexually liberating as white women, given their power to reenforce their hypersexualization and fetishization. Asian men struggle to be seen as potential partners, viewed as insufficiently masculine by white women (Kao et al., 2018). In addition, less class-privileged women often arrive on campus with committed partners from back home. Between the pressures from home to settle down young and an alienating campus culture premised on partying and hooking up, these women are prevented from fully engaging in campus life and their partners interfere with their self-development projects. Without a foothold on campus, they are drawn back into the demands of their home communities and sacrifice educational opportunities, upward mobility, and career progression for early marriage (Hamilton, 2016; Hamilton & Armstrong, 2009).

While hookup culture certainly makes space for new behaviors, and new ways into relationships, the benefits are not evenly dispersed. The poor treatment women face during hookups leads them to conclude that committed monogamous relationships are a better bet (Dalessandro, 2019; Hamilton & Armstrong, 2009). Dalessandro (2019) finds that women interpret casual sex and nonmonogamy as a sign of emotional immaturity. While they feel comfortable engaging in these behaviors early in their college careers, they expect to mature out of them as they move through college. One catalyst for this perspective is women's disappointment with their hookup experiences. A persistent sexual double standard means they are judged more harshly than men for engaging in non-relational sex (Allison & Risman, 2013; Bogle, 2008; Wade, 2017). Rather than one valid experience among many, women who hook up are assumed to lack self-esteem and have emotional problems (Dalessandro, 2019). Because they are unable to secure kind treatment during a hookup, women associate relationships with better treatment that won't harm their self-esteem (Dalessandro, 2019), although Hamilton and Armstrong (2009) caution that college women often endure abusive treatment in committed relationships as well, creating a double-bind for women.

Thus, monogamy becomes the only appropriate relationship form. Women trade the often-denigrating sexism of hookup culture for the benevolent sexism of dating culture (Lamont, 2014; Lever et al., 2015), which feels better given that it comes with some benefits (Becker & Wright, 2011). As a result, women are often inclined to support dating

norms; they are a reward, and they make women feel special and cared for. But higher support for benevolent sexism is connected to higher support for gendered relationship norms (Bermudez et al., 2015). At the same time, challenging benevolent sexism often triggers hostile sexism (Manne, 2018). This disincentivizes any challenges. With these limited options, dating may seem preferable, even though it comes with the same worn narratives about men and women. But after years of hookup culture, many college students buy in to these beliefs.

4 | RECONCILING WOMEN'S SELF-DEVELOPMENT AND GENDERED DATING

The increased commitment to heterosexual women's self-development and gender equality challenges the beliefs on which gendered dating is premised. At present, women's college graduation rates exceed men's, and many women seek to be achievers in their own right, delaying marriage and pursuing lucrative careers (England, 2010). When they partner, they expect to do so with someone who respects their professional ambitions, and they bring the ability to support themselves independently of men to the relationship (Lamont, 2020). Young adults are increasingly supportive of gender equality and egalitarian relationships (Gerson, 2010; Scarborough et al., 2019). Yet while there are cultural scripts for women about how to pursue self-development and professional success as well as scripts for how to support men in intimate relationships, no such guidance exists for how to successfully combine independence and intimacy (Bell, 2013). As Hamilton and Armstrong (2009) show, women face two competing imperatives - a self-development imperative, or the expectation that they delay marriage to focus on educational and career advancement, and a relationship imperative, the expectation that normal women always want a relationship. These are difficult to balance, given that romantic relationships often prove time-greedy for women and thus interfere with women's self-development projects.

Rather than shift dating practices though, women engage in extensive ideological work in order to reconcile the competing messages they receive. While the literature has often emphasized sanctions for gender transgressions to explain conformity, many women also take deep pleasure in gendered dating and want to build feminist identities as empowered, independent women while also engaging in conventional dating practices (Lamont, 2020). Rather than implicate gendered dating as a form of gender inequality then, they draw on narratives of choice feminism (Stone, 2007) in which they view gendered dating as simply an apolitical desire related to personal preference (Lamont, 2014). Gendered processes are thus "de-gendered" (Daminger, 2020) thereby reducing the conflict between their identities as progressive women and their dating practices and desires. This is consistent with both England (2010) and Pepin and Cotter (2018) who argue that people are more committed to undoing gender inequality in the professional than personal spheres.

One way young women have found to combine these expectations is to simply incorporate romantic relationships into their understandings of their self-development (Dalessandro & Wilkins, 2017; Hamilton, 2016). Hamilton (2016) finds that some college women, coached by their mothers to do so, use college as a time to build the social and cultural capital they will need to attract and marry well to do men, which will allow them to then stay at home as mothers. In another example, Dalessandro and Wilkins (2017) find that when relationships end, as they often do for emerging adults, women narrate these breakups as the result of their own neediness and inflated expectations for men, centering the needs of men in the process and viewing bad relationships as opportunities for their own growth. Rather than view these as failures on the part of men, from which men should then learn and grow, women view these as opportunities for self-reflection about what level of treatment they can expect. Men draw on a similar gendered framework, arguing that women's relationship expectations are a threat to their own self-development projects, which lets them off the hook for inadequately responding to the needs of their partners. Instead, men emphasize that as they age, they will become more willing to attend the emotional needs of partners (Dalessandro, 2021).

In the process, women's self-development narratives reinforce the expectation that women sacrifice their own needs for those of men, the belief that demands of men are "unrealistic," and situate women as the emotional caretakers of men (Dalessandro, 2021; Dalessandro & Wilkins, 2017), or opt out of romantic relationships all together (Hamil-

ton & Armstrong, 2009). Men's, on the other hand, reflect their expectation that their ambitions not be constrained by a relationship, setting the stage for future expectations about who should sacrifice their career for their relationship (Wong, 2017). Some men even take an instrumental view of relationships, seeing them as a helpful addition to meeting their own professional goals (Dalessandro, 2021). On the surface, it may seem like self-development narratives would work to undermine women's communal role, but in practice they reinforce the expectation that women attune themselves to men while men attune themselves to their own needs and desires.

Given heterosexual men's resistance to deeper change, women may try to avoid men whom they think will interfere with their self-development and egalitarian goals by dating those they view as more progressive (Lamont, 2020; Vasquez-Tokos, 2017). Vasquez-Tokos (2017) found that this process was also "color-coded;" a number of the Latina women she interviewed sought to avoid relationships with Latino men, as they associated them with their domineering fathers specifically and patriarchal gender relations more generally. Some Asian women make similar claims, arguing that they did not want to date Asian men whom they viewed as more traditional and controlling than white men (Lamont, 2020). While of course not all men of color are less progressive than white men, and in reality, very few white men enact egalitarian ideologies in their relationships (Gerson, 2010), this narrative persists (Dellinger, 2004; Pyke, 1996). Indeed, other research confirms the ease with which privileged white men can incorporate feminine-typed behavior, draw on egalitarian narratives, and distance themselves from misogyny and toxic masculinity while still supporting practices and beliefs that reinforce gender inequality (Lamont, 2015; Pascoe & Hollander, 2016; Wilkins, 2009).

For many class-privileged, college-educated women then, self-development is understood as a way to not only develop professionally, but also to prepare for long-term commitment, in particular marriage (Fallon & Stockstill, 2018). Delayed commitment, undertaken deliberately, is about figuring out what they want in a partner and from a relationship. In addition, it is part of becoming "marriage material," as both men and women view professional success as necessary traits in a partner (Cherlin, 2009; Lamont, 2020). But rather than shift relationship expectations, this self-development period "acts more like an extended finishing school, postponing but not diminishing the value of marriage as a goal" (Fallon & Stockstill, 2018, p. 6). After a period of self-development, women then shift their focus to relationship formation, or the "push to partner," in which they will now pursue their desire to build a family. What Fallon and Stockstill (2018) find then is that elite women are afforded this period of self-development, but that it comes with a cost. Once they hit the socially sanctioned time to partner, they face gendered scrutiny and the expectation that they find a partner and settle down.

This delay in marriage engaged in by professional class women means that they have extended time between leaving their childhood home and family formation in which to engage in self-development. This would indicate an opportunity to develop skills and resources that would strengthen their negotiating power in romantic relationships. However, women remain cognizant of certain biological constraints on the courtship process. While they do not wish to form long-term attachments at a young age, nor do they wish to delay them to the extent that they imperil their ability to have biological children with their partners (Brown & Patrick, 2018).

The leads to a "condensed courtship clock," in which women may feel they have a very short period of time to find a spouse. This potentially tips the balance of power to men. Women start to feel that they should "settle" for their best option rather than hold out and risk not finding a partner before their fertility declines (Fallon & Stockstill, 2018), especially given the devaluation of women as they age (Dalessandro, 2021). Those with sufficient resources, however, may opt to freeze their eggs to address this pressure to partner quickly. Because a pressure to settle conflicts with beliefs about romantic love, women "disentangled romance from reproduction" in order to allow them to time to find the "right" partner (Brown & Patrick, 2018). But women also used egg freezing to signal to potential partners that they were not in a rush, or as a "desperation avoidance strategy" (Brown & Patrick, 2018, p. 971), indicating that women knew how they might potentially be evaluated by men.

Thus, narratives of desperation follow women even as they place greater emphasis on independence and empowerment, and translate into their dating practices (Alarie, 2019; Lamont, 2014). Lamont (2014) found that while women were happy to be agentic behind the scenes, this was still seen as a taboo pathway and therefore needed to

remain hidden from public view (see also Sassler & Miller, 2017). Alarie (2019) examined the relationship between older women and younger men to see if the unexpected age coupling shifted gendered narratives about dating and relationship progression. Perhaps given that the women were often more experienced, they would also be more inclined to embrace an agentic role when dating. But what she found instead was that the cultural narratives of older women as less desirable kept them from embracing this role.

While these findings certainly challenge the argument that women are remaining passive, they also demonstrate the powerful persistence of the expectation that men take the lead in dating and relationships and the fear women have about the judgment leveled at them should the relationship proceed differently. While men could simply apply a feminist label to themselves should women take the lead, women were still worried about being viewed as more desperate than empowered (Alarie, 2019; Lamont, 2020). Rather than actively seek a partner by asking people out on dates, women may “cultivate openness” by engaging in many activities in which they can meet and “encourage romantic advances from men” (Fallon & Stockstill, 2018, p. 10). Although women may have more space to navigate their own professional pathways, they may feel even greater constraint when they are ready to build a relationship. Instead of feeling as though they now wield greater power given their age, experience, and resources (Dalessandro, 2021), they feel even more limited in their options and with less time to find a compatible partner.

5 | ONLINE DATING

One of the major changes to dating in recent decades is the broad adoption of online dating and dating apps. The majority of young adults now meet partners through these mediums (Rosenfeld & Thomas, 2012), which offer the potential to alter the playing field on which dating takes place. After all, women sign up for these sites which is a way of actively indicating interest in a romantic or sexual partner and may take a more active role in relationship formation as a result (McWilliams & Barrett, 2014). Still, many of the same gendered patterns that take place in face-to-face interactions emerge in this context as well (Berkowitz et al., 2021; Rudder, 2014; Sharabi & Dykstra-Devette, 2019).

Online dating apps face accusations that they promote superficiality, given that photos drive interest (Rudder, 2014) and profiles reduce people to a list of traits (Finkel et al., 2012). This reinforces a narrow set of cultural beliefs about what makes women and men attractive. The same hierarchy of desirability and gendered racism that shapes in person interactions is exacerbated online and influences who gets contacted and by whom and how they are treated in these interactions (Curington et al., 2021). Women are contacted by men significantly more than men are contacted by women (Rudder, 2014; Timmermans & Courtois, 2018). Women note that they are inundated with these messages. Those who are more conventionally attractive receive even more. As a result, women often find online dating to be overwhelming and struggle to keep up with the messages they receive (Rudder, 2014). Men feel frustrated, but also compelled to continue given that women are not contacting them (Lamont, 2020).

In response to these issues, Whitney Wolfe Herd created Bumble, an app explicitly designed so that women must take an active role in the process. She noted that the app was “100 percent feminist” because it required women to initiate the conversations. The goal was to interrupt the gendered interactional expectations and reduce online harassment in the process (Yashari, 2015). Research shows that women experience the same harassment online as they do in face-to-face situations, or what Adeyinka-Skold (2020a) refers to as cyberaggression. Men often quickly sexualize online conversations. They may send unwanted sexual images, as well as hostile and denigrating messages when women turn them down. After all, part of the appeal of “cyber-courting” is that interested parties can try on new “dating personas” in a low-stakes environment (Lunquist & Curington, 2019, p. 24–25), but which may potentially also protect those who are interested in harassing women. While Bumble was designed so that women must reach out first as a strategy to reduce men’s negative reactions to rejection, women still report spending a great deal of their time on the app screening potential partners and managing information due to safety fears (Pruchniewska, 2020). Men on the app still seem to struggle with rejection (Pruchniewska, 2020) and may not be invested in Bumble’s feminist agenda that put them in the passenger’s seat (Orchard, 2019).

In spite of these challenges, some women still find online dating to be more empowering than in person ways of initiating relationships, a sorry reflection of the fears and aggression they also regularly face in person (Lundquist & Curington, 2019). Bumble in particular does push women outside of their comfort zone and many reported greater confidence initiating contact once they got over their initial hesitation (Pruchniewska, 2020). In this context, they can control the terms under which they meet with a partner and feel better able to communicate sexual boundaries. Although they report fears of violence, women also develop a number of strategies to address these concerns. Still, this demonstrates the gender divide in how men and women approach online dating as men do not report the same fears; they instead focus on sending nonthreatening signals to women (Lundquist & Curington, 2019).

Women of color have the added burden of navigating gendered racism and limited dating pools (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020a, 2020b). They experience sexual racism, as they are fetishized based on controlling images of their sexuality which often revolve around hypersexualization by white men (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020a; Currington et al., 2021). In an attempt to screen for these issues, some women of color and mixed-race women list that they will not date white men (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020b) or use political messaging about Black Lives Matter as a litmus test to see if someone is dating material (Buggs, 2017). But depending on their location, they then limit their pool (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020b). While online dating is often represented as a panacea to thin markets, it is still limited by the availability of partners. If they live in certain areas, women of color struggle to find partners of their same race, which many find preferable. White rural areas can be especially challenging because while they may be open to dating white men to increase their dating pool, symbols of white rural masculinity are often viewed as evidence of racism (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020b). High rates of incarceration and low employment among Black men in other areas create imbalanced dating markets in which Black women outnumber Black men, making it hard for them to enact their dating preferences (Clarke, 2011; Simons et al., 2021). These thin markets leave women of color with limited power to challenge the terms of engagement if they want to date at all given the small dating pools, although some may move in order to increase their dating options (Adeyinka-Skold, 2020b).

Finally, although dating technologies have transformed the market, and are indeed, ubiquitous, some young adults view them as a less than desirable way to meet people. Rather than view them solely as a positive tool to find partners, they see these technologies as having a downside as well, and assume they encourage dishonesty, thus considering these relationships as “less authentic” than those initiated in person (Dalessandro, 2018). However, given how common online dating is, young adults feel that it is increasingly difficult to meet people in person, leading them to glorify “old-fashioned values” and gendered courtship. Interestingly, older adults have a different experience, finding online dating preferable to what they see as limited in-person options which they view as more suitable to young adults (McWilliams & Barrett, 2014). But while older men view online dating as a way to hasten a new commitment, older women see it as a way to ease back into the dating scene and find companionship, often concerned about the burdensome caregiving roles that could come with greater commitment (McWilliams & Barrett, 2014). Still, in spite of this supposed greater desire by older men for quick commitment, when older women build online profiles, they focus on describing their desire for commitment (Griffin & Fingerman, 2017), evidence of the persistent relational imperative. They also feel constrained by the limited number of available older men (Griffin & Fingerman, 2017), many of whom express a desire for younger women (McWilliams & Barrett, 2014), thereby reifying the declining social value of women as they age (Dalessandro, 2021).

6 | ECONOMIC DISADVANTAGE AND EXCLUSION FROM NORMATIVE RELATIONSHIP PATHWAYS

Much of the literature on dating has focused on privileged young adults, examining dating for the population idealized in the popular imagination and which has the resources to enact conventional gendered dating norms. This group presents an interesting puzzle because we might expect them to be best situated to challenge these practices given women's educational credentials, professional pathways, and economic resources, and the emphasis on gender equal-

ity. At the same time, they are viewed as trend-setters (Stone, 2007); middle-class norms often shape expectations for everyone, regardless of whether they have the means to enact them (Hays, 1996). Thus, there is often interest in those setting the norms and how their behaviors may shift to shape new understandings of gender. Yet, the dating system originated in the working-class, which did not have access to private space and thus creatively reimagined ways to form partnerships (Bailey, 1988). But while there has been a great deal of scholarship on relationship formation in lower-income communities (Edin & Kefalas, 2003; Edin & Nelson, 2013), less has focused specifically on dating practices and the role gender plays to see if a similar process is currently playing out. Instead, research has focused on the challenges that occur as a result of economic and social exclusion, such as dating violence or early nonmarital childbearing (Edin & Kefalas, 2003; Miller, 2008), rather than transformative potential. Still, the research that does exist suggests limited challenges to the norms that guide dating.

Ray's (2018) research demonstrates considerable consistency between the dating desires of low-income teenagers and the cultural norms and broad cultural images that shape dating more broadly. Low-income teenagers too aspire to the normative dating ideal whereby the man enacts a particular role that involves romancing the woman through gestures that require resources. However, low-income teenage boys lack the income that allows for these cultural enactments of romance. They are unable to pick girls up for dates, or pay for nice dinners, and thus the challenge for these couples becomes how to do romance on a budget. Sassler and Miller (2017) uncover similar challenges among the service class young adults they interviewed. Many of the women wanted more romance, lamenting that their relationships started with activities such as hanging out and playing video games together, making it difficult to determine a relationship start date. This indicates that the values each group brings to the dating process are not unique. What does matter, then, is the ability to enact these behaviors in a way that supports romance and relationship building. Unfortunately, even when people from disadvantaged economic groups access certain conventional actions, the professional class continues to distinguish itself with an emphasis on ever more creative romantic enactments (Swidler, 2001).

Undocumented immigrant men express similar concerns about economic barriers to dating and relationship formation (Pila 2016) and Enriquez (2020) finds that illegality is experienced in gendered ways when dating. Constrained in their ability to earn a good income, undocumented men worry that they will not be desirable partners. Because they wanted to pay for dates in order to enact the provider role, they looked for ways to lower the costs of dating, either by frequenting less expensive venues, going out less frequently, or finding free or low-cost activities such as hiking. This approach was considered preferable to asking women to help with the expenses (Enriquez, 2020). Pila (2016) found that undocumented men's inability to pay for dates created enough conflict in couples that it could lead to breakups. Because the men in her study often worked low-wage jobs and helped support their families, they had limited disposable income and felt torn between these competing demands on their money. On the other hand, undocumented women rarely expressed the same level of concern despite articulating egalitarian ideals that might compel them to help pay. Enriquez (2020) shows how they were instead able to be selectively egalitarian; because men did not expect them to pay, they simply chipped in when they had money.

The crisis in expectations is particularly acute among the working-class, who feel trapped between the expectations of the past and their desires for the future (Silva, 2013). Despite new narratives about the value of and desire for egalitarian relationships, working-class men continue to lean on cultural understandings of men as providers. But without the earning power of the industrial working-class man that undergirded this frame of reference, men feel they have little to offer romantic partners. They cannot afford to pay for dates, often live at home with parents, and work long and irregular hours in unstable jobs (Silva, 2013). Modern dating is often premised on assumptions about independence in emerging adulthood. But many young adults are not independent. They may lack the private space required for intimacy, the vehicle necessary for easy transportation, or the time to explore socially, and may feel obligated to support other family members (Enriquez, 2020; Pila, 2016; Sassler & Miller, 2017; Silva, 2013). Unable to shift this conceptualization of their role and build egalitarian relationships that provide a different type of support to partners, men instead opt out of dating and committed relationships while women lament men's unwillingness to commit and view men's stagnation as a personality flaw (Silva, 2013). Working-class women focus on personal growth

in the face of relationship turmoil while continuing to strive for a gender complementary normative family unit (Schell & Silva, 2020).

We might expect these shifts and exclusions to result in a greater creative reimagining of dating. After all, in queer relationships, LGBTQ people develop inventive ways to build intimacy when they are excluded from normative pathways (Lamont, 2017; Pfeffer, 2012; Stacey, 2011). And there do appear to be some shifts taking place in families, at least in regard to fatherhood, as low-income fathers invest time, rather than money, in their children (Edin & Nelson, 2013; Randles, 2020). But these normative shifts have been slower to reach romantic relationships, as the majority still want relationships that lead to marriage (Cherlin, 2009; Dalessandro, 2021), and "'marriageability' has become synonymous with employment" (Bridges & Boyd, 2016, p. 53). Unfortunately, for most, an inability to redefine heterosexuality as something other than a patriarchal institution appears to constrain heterosexual couples, which leads them to try to make normative practices and pathways work, rather than rejecting them in favor of something that better reflects their needs and abilities (Ward, 2020). Deeply held beliefs about gender combined with a lack of resources lead to shame rather than a rejection of exclusionary cultural norms.

7 | CONCLUSION

Research on gendered dating demonstrates the remarkable staying power of conventional practices and beliefs in light of the rapid changes to gender norms in other aspects of social life. While new pathways to relationship formation have developed, such as delayed marriage, hooking up, and online dating, heterosexual men and women have incorporated old frameworks into emerging practices. This is surprising given that many of the shifts are a result of women's increased independence, economic success, and focus on self-development, and both women and men express a desire for more egalitarian relationships. Yet, as England (2010) makes clear, women have a greater incentive to challenge gender inequality in the public sphere than in the private sphere. Plus, as she demonstrates, the ideology of liberal individualism that led to those public opportunities, can also be used to justify private inequalities, as women lean on the rhetoric of choice to make sense of gendered preferences. Even self-declared feminists take pleasure in gendered dating rituals and view them as compatible with a feminist identity (Lamont, 2014).

Although there has been some resistance to research that takes seriously women's internalization of gender norms (Ridgeway & Correll, 2004), socialization as a concept is not inconsistent with analyses of power that make clear the impact of patriarchy (Guhin et al., 2021), and future research should not shy away from attending to the pleasure people get from gender-differentiated and gender normative acts. While gender policing absolutely shapes conformity to gendered dating, so too does desire. How do we challenge the inequality inherent in gendered dating as well as its broader consequences, when these seem abstract and the pleasures more tangible? This question has implications for understanding the persistence of other forms of gender inequality as well, including lessons for scholars and activists seeking to help women understand the structural forces that shape their lives. For example, feminists have faced backlash for what appears to some as an unwillingness to acknowledge the pleasure many women get from parenting. As a result, some women end up feeling alienated from rather than invested in feminist arguments about the larger repercussions of gender complementarity.

Social relational contexts are strategic sites for the production of gender inequality (Ridgeway & Correll, 2004). As Ridgeway and Correll (2004) argue, any practice that preserves the belief that men and women are fundamentally different, supports the persistence of gender inequality more broadly. Conventional dating does just this, as narratives about why these practices exist draw on essentialist beliefs about men and women. While the gender revolution has convinced many people that women deserve opportunities and choices, it has been less successful at convincing people that men and women are not fundamentally different. Given the support for egalitarian essentialism (Pepin & Cotter, 2018), dating is good site for thinking about the mechanisms that allow these beliefs to persist and how support for these conventions reflects broader understandings of gender that shape other aspects of social life as well. Thus, dating remains an important research site as we work to understand what interventions can restart the gender

revolution, especially in interpersonal relationships where there appears to be a backslide in the wake of Covid-19 (Mize et al., 2021). Part of this is of course considering what policy changes can be implemented to undermine gender inequality, but we cannot legislate dating and everyday individual resistance remains important to challenging the gender system (Ridgeway & Correll, 2004).

Moving forward, researchers should explore the conditions under which challenges and changes to dating norms actually do occur. What shifts, for example, give women more negotiating power as they date? What disrupts the agentic/communal binary that shapes and restricts behavior? When and how does exclusion from normative pathways actually lead to change? What leads men and women to contest the beliefs that undergird traditional dating practices and build new understandings of gender? Must practices change in order to shift beliefs, or must beliefs change in order to significantly shift practices? What does it even mean to date as equals and how do varying conceptions of equality shape practices? What are the implications of this? How can we apply the lessons from LGBTQ dating and relationships to heterosexual couples? Answering these questions will provide a better understanding of the conditions under which gender essentialist beliefs actually break down, with implications for gender research more broadly as such beliefs support multiple forms of inequality in work, family, intimacy, politics, and public policy.

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